Enhancing Proactive Emotional Support Systems with Open-Source LLMs: Multi-Agent Architecture, Need-State Memory, and Psychological Evaluation

Arpit Bhomia-12340340, Ashish Ranjan-12340370

***Abstract*—People in distress often do not ask for help, and when a support system starts the conversation they reply briefly and indirectly. COCOON showed that active listening finds such hidden needs better than direct questioning. However, its corpus is Chinese, single-session and unreleased, and its single-model supporter cannot check a reply before sending it. We rebuild COCOON in English with open models and improve it in four ways:**

- **A new corpus. COCOON_EN contains 2,369 linked conversations in which simulated people resist, change and come back after real time gaps.**
- **A safer supporter. We replace the single model with four agents (Analyzer, Strategist, Generator and Critic), guarded by a calibrated safety gate that blocks intrusive replies.**
- **Turn-level metrics. New metrics show which supporter turn caused resistance.**
- **A need-state memory. It carries checked beliefs about a person's needs from one session to the next.**

Going beyond our proposal, we also test activation steering and preference alignment as cheaper ways to make the supporter gentler. In the untuned four-agent test with held-out simulated users, the gate lowers intrusiveness while keeping the released-and-intrusive turn share within its 10% budget. Preference alignment gives the largest drop in intrusiveness against its own baseline, at no extra cost. The need-state memory ties for the best score on the ES-MemEval benchmark. Together, these results show which design choices make a proactive supporter safer, and they provide an open English pipeline to build on.

***Index Terms*—Proactive emotional support, multi-agent dialogue, safety gate, reactance, conversational memory, preference alignment.**

I. Introduction

Most emotional-support chat systems assume that the user asks for help: the user starts the conversation, names the problem and is happy to answer questions. Many people in distress do not act this way. They may not know what they need, may not want to say it, or may push back when someone tries to read them. In a *proactive* setting the system starts the conversation, and the person's first answers are short and guarded. The supporter must then guess the need hidden behind these answers without pushing so hard that the person shuts down. Psychological reactance, the urge to resist when one's freedom feels threatened, shows why this is hard: a guess made too early can cause exactly the withdrawal it was meant to prevent [2].

COCOON [1] studied this setting using active listening. Its authors:

- built user profiles from an emotion, a feeling, a need and some memories, with a chain of reasons leading from the surface feeling to the real need;
- used GPT-4o to write proactive dialogues in two stages, listening and then suggesting;
- removed weak dialogues with the Active-Empathic Listening Scale (AELS);
- labelled every supporter turn with a free-text *Analysis* and *Strategy*.

A model fine-tuned on this data found hidden needs more often than models trained on other datasets, and did worse when trained without the labels. The authors also showed that asking more questions made users less comfortable.

Our proposal pointed out three more gaps:

1) The user is modelled for one conversation only, so needs that change, get solved or come back over time cannot be represented.
2) One model analyses, plans and writes in a single step, so there is no point where a reply can be checked and stopped.
3) Resistance is only measured on average, so nothing shows which supporter turn caused it.

COCOON's data, pipeline and English role-play prompts are not available, so we first had to rebuild the pipeline in English. Fig. 1 shows the COCOON pipeline and where each gap lies.

We ask six research questions:

- **RQ1:** Can the pipeline be rebuilt in English with open models, seeded from real situations and extended to several linked sessions?
- **RQ2:** Does training with the Analysis and Strategy labels help, as in COCOON, and can the model beat reactive baselines?
- **RQ3:** In a supporter made of several agents plus a safety gate, which part lowers intrusiveness, and does the gate keep its error budget?
- **RQ4:** Can turn-level metrics show which supporter turns cause resistance?
- **RQ5:** Does a need-state memory help across sessions compared with simpler memories?
- **RQ6:** How do activation steering and preference alignment compare with the gate?

Contributions. We do not claim to beat COCOON: the language, models, simulated users and judges all differ, so the numbers cannot be compared directly. Our contributions are:

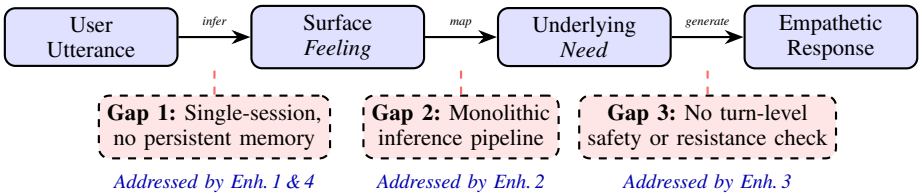


Fig. 1. COCOON's Feeling→Need→Response pipeline (solid) and the three gaps (dashed) that our enhancements address. Gap 1: no cross-session memory or time modelling. Gap 2: all reasoning in a single forward pass with no point to inspect it. Gap 3: no per-turn safety gate or resistance measurement.

1) An open, English, multi-session rebuild of the COCOON pipeline, and the corpus it produces.
2) A four-agent supporter with a grounding check, a depth ladder and a calibrated safety gate. It is tested in a 2×2 design that separates the effect of the agents from the effect of the gate.
3) Turn-level intrusiveness and reactance metrics, with a counterfactual version, computed for every system.
4) A need-state memory that stores quoted, checkable beliefs. We compare it with standard memories in dialogue and on ES-MemEval [6].
5) Model steering and preference alignment, which were not part of our proposal. We test them against the gate as weight-level and activation-level ways to reduce intrusiveness, and check them for side effects.

II. Related Work

Liu et al. [3] defined the emotional-support conversation task and released ESConv, which is based on Helping Skills theory. ExTES [4] added more scenarios and strategies using LLM-written dialogues. Other datasets added explanations of strategy choices or focused on mental health in Chinese. All of these assume a user who asks for help, and they label strategies from a fixed list. COCOON [1] introduced the proactive setting, where the system starts the conversation, together with free-text strategy labels. We follow both ideas.

COCOON built its data on active listening and on the idea that a feeling points to an underlying need. It evaluated with the AELS, the Comforting Responses Scale (CRS) and the Ratings of Alter Competence (RAC). We use the same ideas and scales, but write the English versions ourselves and score them with open models. Our starting situations come from EmpatheticDialogues [5], which were written by real people rather than by a language model.

Splitting a supporter into several agents is not new. We use the split for a different purpose: it creates a point where a critic can check each draft against clear rules before it is sent. Psychological reactance [2] has so far been measured on whole conversations. Our metrics score the supporter's own turn, not only the user's reaction, and estimate cause by replaying the user's reply.

For long-term memory, ES-MemEval [6] tests emotional-support memory on five skills: extracting information, modelling the user, reasoning about time, detecting conflicts, and knowing when not to answer. Most memories store facts or past turns. Ours stores the chain of needs and records which guesses were confirmed or denied.

Finally, COCOON changed how often its model asked questions by editing the model's internal representations. We use contrastive activation addition [7] to push replies from intrusive towards gentle. We also use Direct Preference Optimization (DPO) [8] to teach the same preference through training.

III. Proposed Methodology

A. Overview

COCOON_EN is the name of our English corpus and the system built on it. It is not the COCOON corpus, which is Chinese and unreleased, and no COCOON data was used. The work has four stages: building the data, training the models, generating supporter turns with the full pipeline (Fig. 2), and evaluating. Two open models from different families do all the work:

- **Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct** plays the supporter and the simulated user.
- **Mistral-Nemo-Instruct-2407 (12B)** writes the user profiles, filters and labels the dialogues, and later acts as the judge.

No paid or closed model is used anywhere.

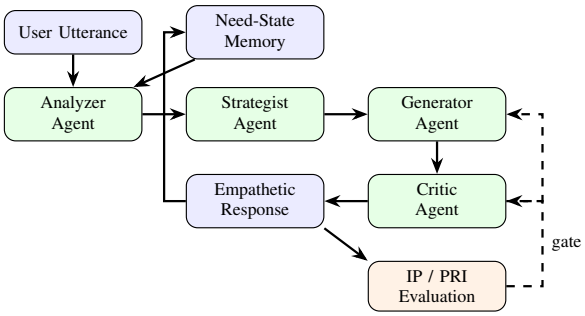


Fig. 2. The system pipeline. Turn-level metrics gate the Critic, and responses update the need-state memory for cross-session continuity.

B. Building the COCOON_EN Corpus

Seeds. COCOON created its user situations entirely with an LLM. We instead started from EmpatheticDialogues [5], whose situations were written by people. Each candidate situation was tagged with an ESConv problem type and checked for whether it could support a three-step chain of needs. Of 2,000 candidates, 85.5% passed, and we kept 1,000.

Profiles. Each seed became a profile with:

- an emotion and a surface feeling, which is how the person would say it out loud;
- a three-step *need chain*, from the surface feeling to a middle need to the *terminal need*, which the person never says directly;
- four recent events that the person can talk about;
- a visible persona;
- hidden traits: a resistance level (low, medium or high), and what makes the person open up or close down.

Three checks reject weak profiles:

- the chain must have three non-empty steps;
- the terminal need must not just repeat the surface feeling;
- a model check must confirm that the chain makes sense.

Resistance was set at a 1:2:1 ratio of low, medium and high. The profiles were split by person into 720 training, 100 validation, 100 test and 80 calibration profiles, and test and calibration people never appear in the training data.

These profile memories belong to the *simulated user* and are hidden from the supporter. They are different from the supporter's need-state memory (Section III-G), which is built only from what the person says.

Dialogues. COCOON wrote each whole dialogue in one model call. We generate it turn by turn: the same Qwen model plays both roles, with separate instructions and a warmer sampling temperature for the user. Only one model needs to be loaded, so everything fits on a single GPU.

The simulated user is told that they did *not* ask for help and should stay guarded at first. They open up when the supporter reflects them well and is patient. They close down when given early advice, told feelings they never said, or questioned too much. Each session has 8–12 supporter turns. As in COCOON, it has a listening stage (the first 60%) and a suggestion stage.

Linked sessions with time gaps. Each person gets 2–4 sessions. Before each follow-up we sample a gap of 1 to 56 days and a change in the person's situation: the need was *resolved*, *intensified*, or *displaced* by a new concern. The model then updates the profile to match, and the follow-up opens with a check-in that mentions the time gap. A final check confirms that every chain of sessions is complete and in order. Fig. 3 shows this structure.

Filtering. A session is removed if:

- its structure is broken;
- the user says their hidden need in the first two turns, which would make the task trivial;
- it contains non-English text, since Qwen sometimes drifts into Chinese;
- it fails the AELS check, which requires an average of 5 out of 7 and no item below 3.

If one session of a person fails, that person's later sessions are dropped too, leaving **2,369 sessions**.

Annotation. For every supporter turn, Mistral-Nemo wrote an *Analysis* of what the user's words show, a *Strategy* phrase describing the move, and a depth level. This gives **21,429 labelled turns**. The labels are not repetitive: almost every strategy phrase is different.

Training examples. Each labelled turn becomes one training example. The input is a time-gap note, an empty memory line and the conversation so far. The target is either the Analysis, the Strategy and the reply (*with thoughts*), or the reply alone (*without thoughts*).

C. Fine-Tuning

We fine-tuned Qwen2.5 at three sizes (0.5B, 3B and 7B) with QLoRA [9]: 4-bit weights with small trainable adapters (rank 32, α = 64). The training settings were a learning rate of 2×10^{-4} and three epochs, with the loss computed only on target tokens. The checkpoint with the best validation loss is kept.

D. The Four-Agent Supporter

COCOON's supporter thinks and writes in one step. We split it into four agents (Fig. 2). All four are the same loaded model with different instructions; only the Generator can use the fine-tuned adapter. Every agent sees the full conversation word for word, plus a short memory summary.

- **Analyzer:** reads the user's feeling and possible needs, with a confidence for each. *Every claim must quote the user.*
- **Depth ladder:** a simple rule, not a model, that decides how deep this turn may go.
- **Strategist:** plans the move within that limit and explains why.
- **Generator:** writes the reply.
- **Critic:** rates the draft on seven intrusiveness items and its depth, then runs rule-based checks.

Grounding check. Every quote the Analyzer gives must appear exactly in a user turn; a claim without a valid quote cannot enter memory. The Critic's rule checks look for six kinds of problems, each with a weight (Table I). Repeating a guess the user has already denied is an automatic block.

TABLE I
GROUNDING PROBLEMS CHECKED BY THE CRITIC

Problem	Weight
Repeats a guess the user denied	1.00 (block)
States a feeling the user never expressed	0.70
Invents a fact	0.70
Goes deeper than the allowed level	0.45
Gives advice nobody asked for	0.40
Brings up a faded or resolved need	0.15

Depth ladder. Every move has one of four levels:

- **L0** reflects what was said;
- **L1** asks an open question;
- **L2** offers a gentle guess;
- **L3** names the need.

If the Analyzer is unsure, the limit is L1. L3 is allowed only when the memory's best guess has been *confirmed* by the user.

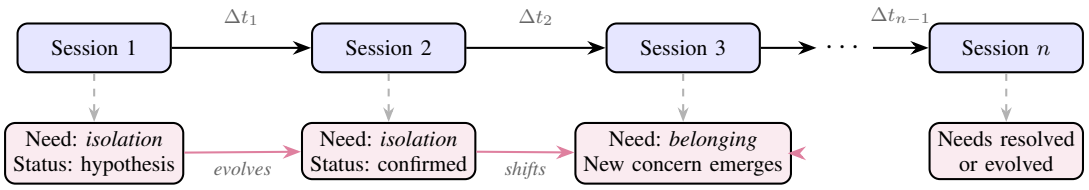


Fig. 3. Multi-session structure. Linked sessions are separated by sampled time gaps (Δt_i), and the user's profile changes between sessions: needs may be confirmed, resolved, or replaced by new concerns.

E. The Critic and the Safety Gate

The Critic combines its own intrusiveness rating with the weighted grounding problems into one risk score. The gate sends the draft if the score is below a threshold λ and no denied guess is repeated. Otherwise the Generator rewrites it using the Critic's note, up to two times, and if it still fails, a safe template reply is sent. The template echoes the user's last words and invites them to say more.

The threshold is not hand-tuned. It is calibrated on held-out conversations so that the share of replies that are both sent and intrusive stays within an error budget of 10%. The untuned and the fine-tuned Generator are calibrated separately.

F. Turn-Level Metrics

Intrusiveness Penalty (IP) scores a supporter turn on seven items, each rated 1–7:

1) gives advice before the user finished explaining;
2) states a feeling or motive the user never expressed;
3) names a need or cause the user never acknowledged;
4) presses for information the user was reluctant to give;
5) reads deeper than invited;
6) ignores a boundary;
7) is likely to feel exposing.

The average is rescaled to 0–1 to express the degree of intrusiveness. Four turns per session are scored.

Psychological Reactance Index (PRI) scores the user's *next* reply on seven signs of reactance [2]: irritation, hostility, arguing back, dismissing, asserting their own control, changing the subject and withdrawing. It is rescaled to 0–1 to express the degree of reactance.

Counterfactual PRI separates resistance the supporter caused from resistance the user already had. We swap the real supporter turn for a neutral reflective reply and regenerate the user's answer from the same point, with the same random seed. Counterfactual PRI is PRI(real) minus PRI(neutral).

Judge rules. The judge never sees the user's resistance level or hidden traits. It must also be a different model from both the supporter and the simulated user; the code refuses to run otherwise.

G. Need-State Memory

Our proposal suggested remembering the supporter's *beliefs about the person's needs*, not a list of facts. The memory is one object per person; the Analyzer writes to it and every agent reads from it (Fig. 2). **Writing.** The surface feeling becomes a root node, and each need hangs under the shallower need it explains. The memory then updates each belief in one of three ways:

- **Confirm:** needs two quotes and a clear "yes" from the user. It raises confidence and lowers competing needs.
- **Deny:** sets confidence to 0 and blocks the guess for good. Everything below a denied need becomes inactive.
- **Resolve:** a need the user says they acted on with success is marked resolved.

Fading. Between sessions, every belief except a denial fades with the time gap. Beliefs fade more slowly once confirmed, and more slowly again each time a later session brings them back. A belief that fades below a floor goes dormant and leaves the summary; it returns at half strength if mentioned again. Every change is written to a log, so any belief can be traced.

Reading. A short summary (at most 320 tokens) gives:

- the best current guess at the real need and its chain;
- up to two competing guesses;
- guesses not yet tested;
- every denied guess, with the user's own words;
- resolved and faded needs.

It goes to all four agents, always next to the full conversation.

Baselines. We compare the need-state memory with three simpler memories that use the same budget:

- **no memory**;
- **a summary** rewritten at the end of each session;
- **word-match retrieval** of the most similar past user turns.

H. Model Steering and Preference Alignment (Beyond the Proposal)

Steering and alignment were not part of our proposal. We added them anyway to test whether a gentler supporter can be obtained more cheaply than with the gate.

Activation steering. We read 400 training conversations twice, once with a "be gentle" and once with a "be intrusive" instruction. The average difference in hidden activations gives a direction [7], which we add to the one-call supporter while it writes.

Preference alignment (DPO). The fine-tuned model wrote four replies to each of 1,200 training conversations. The untuned Qwen Critic, *not* the evaluation judge, rated each reply's intrusiveness. The least and most intrusive replies became a training pair, giving 460 pairs. We then trained with DPO [8] on top of the fine-tuned adapter.

IV. Experimental Setup

A. Models and Hardware

We use one model family for generation and role-play and a separate judge from another family (Table II). All experiments run on one NVIDIA RTX 3060 GPU with 12 GB of memory, with only one model loaded at a time.

Untuned models and the judge run on Ollama (4-bit). Anything that needs a LoRA adapter or a steering hook runs on HuggingFace transformers (4-bit), because Ollama cannot load either.

TABLE II
Models and Their Roles

Model	Role
Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct	supporter and simulated user in the corpus; all four agents; simulated user in every test
Qwen2.5-0.5B/3B/7B + QLoRA	fine-tuned supporters (7B with thoughts is the Generator of the full system)
Mistral-Nemo-12B	profiles, filtering, labels; **the judge** (temperature 0)
ESC-RANK	corpus-quality scorer used by COCOON

B. Test Users

All tests use the 100 held-out test people, or 100 ExTES people where stated. The simulated user takes one of three styles:

- **Proactive:** the corpus role-play. The person did not ask for help.
- **Corrective:** proactive, plus a rule to say "no, that's not it" to wrong guesses. The person's situation also changes between sessions.
- **Reactive:** a person who chose to talk and wants help.

Single-session tests have 100 sessions. Multi-session tests have 310 sessions (100 people with 2–4 sessions each).

C. Scoring

After each run, the judge model is loaded on its own and scores the conversations:

- **Success** asks whether the supporter identified the person's real need, which is given to the judge as the reference. It is rated from "1: not at all" to "7: said it clearly and worked with it," and rescaled to 0–1. So **0.415 means an average rating of about 3.5 out of 7, not a 41.5% success rate**.
- **Session scales:** AELS, CRS, RAC and COCOON's six basic quality ratings.
- **Turn-level scores:** IP, PRI and counterfactual PRI.

D. Statistics

All 95% confidence intervals come from a bootstrap that resamples *people*, not single turns.

Most comparisons are *unpaired*, because each system's sessions use their own random draws. Steering and DPO were run on exactly the same sessions as their controls, so those comparisons are *paired*.

We evaluated 42 main comparisons. The report presents measured differences and bootstrap confidence intervals; the full statistical records are retained in the supplementary result files.

V. Results and Analysis

Unless noted otherwise, the judge is Mistral-Nemo-12B and all scores are on a 0–1 scale. We first examine the corpus, trained models, memory, gate and supporting checks. The ablations then isolate individual design choices. Section VII closes the experiments with the combined fine-tuned, four-agent, memory-enabled system.

A. The Corpus (RQ1)

Table III compares our corpus with the datasets reported in COCOON, and Fig. 4 shows its composition and main counts. The 180 test and calibration profiles have no corpus dialogues by design. Of the 820 training and validation people, 801 kept at least one session.

TABLE III
Datasets Compared (Other Rows as Reported by COCOON [1])

Dataset	Lang.	Setting	Labels	Dialogues	Turns
ESConv	EN	reactive	fixed list	1.3k	11.70
ExTES	EN	reactive	fixed list	11.2k	8.96
COCOON	ZH	proactive	free text	3.5k	18.82
COCOON_EN	EN	proactive*	free text	2,369	20.1

* also multi-session, with time gaps between sessions.

Of 2,493 generated sessions, 2,369 were kept. The 801 people with retained dialogues had one, two, three or four sessions in counts of 21, 250, 272 and 258. Sessions average 20.1 turns (range 16–24), with about 1.15 million words in total. Follow-up gaps range from 1 to 56 days (median 7.6). The 21,429 annotated turns contain 21,354 distinct strategy phrases and yield 18,821 training and 2,608 validation examples per target version.

Quality. We scored 200 of our dialogues and 100 each from ExTES and ESConv with our judge and with ESC-RANK, the scorer COCOON used (Table IV). Our judge gives nearly the same score to all three datasets. ESC-RANK separates them better: our corpus scores below ExTES on diversity, information and skill, and above ESConv on diversity and information. Our user profiles are also more varied than ExTES's on all four diversity measures (Table V); the human-written ESConv profiles are the most varied.

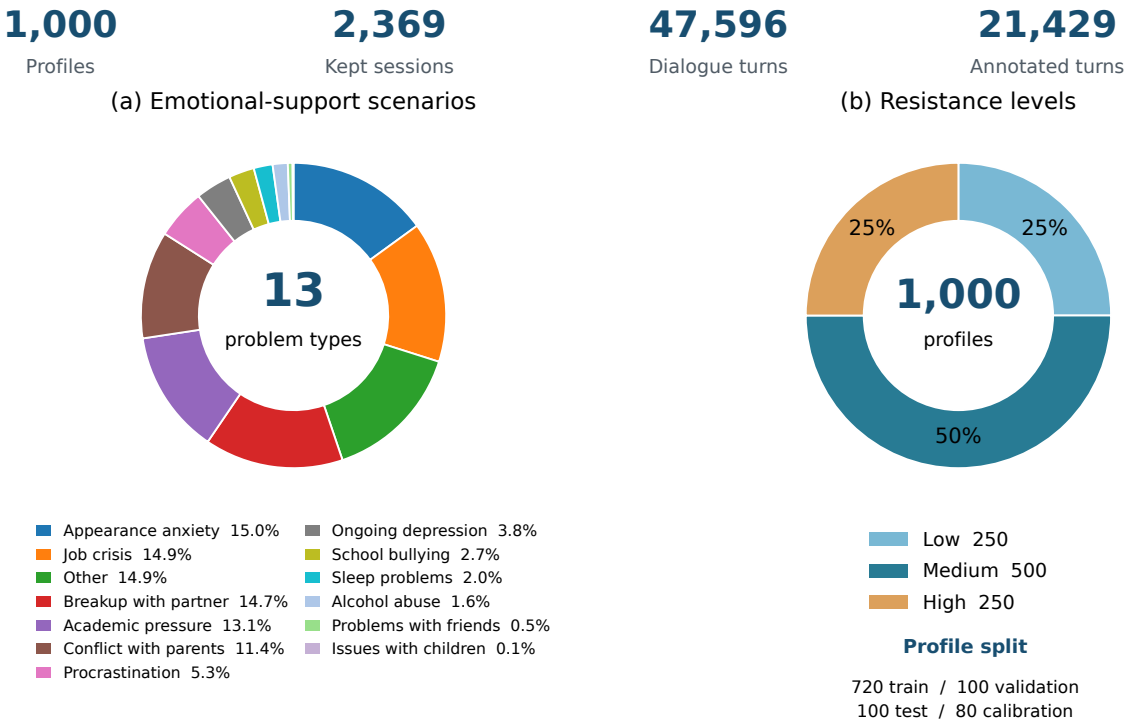


Fig. 4. COCOON_EN corpus overview. Panel (a) shows the 13 problem types; panel (b) shows the assigned resistance levels. Both distributions cover all 1,000 profiles. The counts above summarize the retained corpus.

TABLE IV
DATA QUALITY IN THE FORMAT OF COCOON'S DATA TABLES: OUR JUDGE (BASIC METRICS 0–100; CRS AND RAC 1–7) AND ESC-RANK (×25; MAXIMUM 75)

	Our judge											ESC-RANK					
Dataset	Flu	Div	Emp	Inf	Hum	Skil	Avg	Aff	Neg	Sup	Man	Flu	Div	Emp	Inf	Hum	Skil
Ours (200)	83.3	67.2	83.3	83.2	83.3	83.0	80.5	5.72	1.00	6.26	5.57	75.0	64.9	75.0	56.9	49.9	65.1
ExTES (100)	83.3	73.2	84.2	83.3	83.3	83.3	81.8	5.98	1.00	6.74	6.07	75.0	74.0	75.0	70.2	49.2	74.0
ESConv (100)	82.7	66.0	79.0	81.2	83.0	81.5	78.9	5.88	1.00	6.28	5.63	71.0	54.8	74.8	54.5	50.2	67.5

TABLE V
USER PROFILE DIVERSITY (1,000 PROFILES PER DATASET)

Dataset	Self-BLEU-2	Self-BLEU-4	Distinct-2	Entropy
Ours	0.702	0.398	0.256	8.38
ExTES	0.724	0.450	0.237	7.80
ESConv	0.498	0.146	0.536	8.52

TABLE VI
SINGLE-SESSION TEST (100 PEOPLE; 95% CI; FT = FINE-TUNED)

System	Success	IP	PRI
Untuned 7B	0.383 [.368,.400]	0.065 [.057,.073]	0.192
FT 0.5B, with thoughts	0.397 [.382,.412]	0.103 [.094,.111]	0.244
FT 0.5B, without	0.395 [.378,.413]	0.081 [.074,.089]	0.233
FT 7B, with thoughts	**0.415** [.397,.435]	0.091 [.084,.098]	0.241
FT 7B, without	0.392 [.373,.412]	0.083 [.076,.092]	0.223

B. Fine-Tuned Supporters and Reactive Baselines (RQ2)

Table VI tests the fine-tuned models in single sessions with the proactive user, with no memory and no gate. The fine-tuned 7B with thoughts has the highest Success. However, all fine-tuned models are more intrusive than the untuned model.

In COCOON's format. Table VII shows the same 7B models with all of COCOON's evaluation scores: Success Rate, the six basic metrics, and the CRS and RAC dimensions. These values are computed from our saved judge scores. The basic metrics are almost the same for every model, because our judge saturates at about 83. Only Success separates the models.

Reactive baselines. Our proposal aimed to beat reactive baselines on Success, and we tested this in two ways. *Neither met that aim.*

First, the same untuned supporter talked to a proactive user and to a reactive user. With the guarded proactive user it showed an IP difference of −0.024 and a lower Success estimate. These results describe the additional challenge of

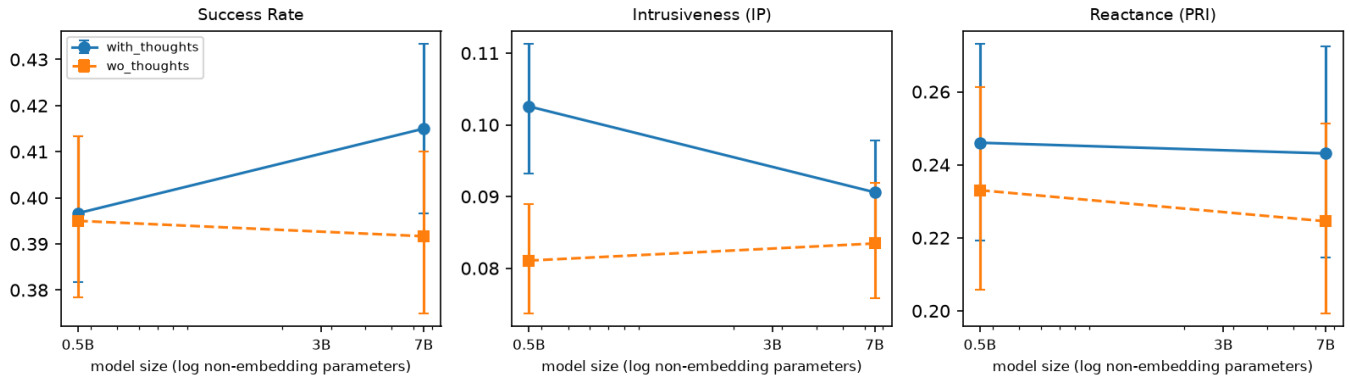


Fig. 5. Single-session results with and without thoughts at the evaluated model sizes. There is no 3B result point because that size was not evaluated in this dialogue test. "Success Rate" in the image denotes the normalized Success rating used in this report, not a percentage of successful sessions.

TABLE VII
OUR PEOPLE, IN THE FORMAT OF COCOON'S MAIN RESULTS TABLE (SUCCESS 0–1; BASIC METRICS 0–100; CRS AND RAC 1–7)

Model	Success	Flu	Div	Emp	Inf	Hum	Skil	Aff	Neg	Sup	Man
Untuned 7B	0.383	83.2	67.0	82.5	82.3	83.3	82.5	5.71	1.00	6.26	5.59
Fine-tuned 7B, with thoughts	**0.415**	83.3	67.2	83.3	83.2	83.3	83.0	5.79	1.00	6.30	5.58
Fine-tuned 7B, without thoughts	0.392	83.3	67.7	83.3	83.2	83.3	83.2	5.82	1.00	6.36	5.66

engaging a user who did not ask for help.

Second, we tested the 7B trained on 15,000 ExTES examples with reply-only targets. Table VIII shows this model on our profiles and on ExTES profiles. Table IX compares the ExTES-trained and our-corpus-trained models on ExTES profiles using the original paper's score format. ExTES profiles have no hidden reference need, so their Success scores are not directly comparable to reference-based Success on our profiles.

TABLE VIII
EXTES-TRAINED 7B ON OUR AND EXTES TEST PROFILES (100 PER GROUP, ONE SESSION)

Trained on	Tested on	IP	PRI	Success
ExTES	our people	0.109	0.262	0.427
ExTES	ExTES people	0.109	0.294	0.517†

† scored without a reference need (ExTES has none).

TABLE IX
EXTES PEOPLE, IN THE FORMAT OF COCOON'S EXTES TABLE

Model	Success†	Basic	Aff	Neg	Sup	Man
Ours-trained 7B	0.453	81.0	5.00	1.29	6.41	5.74
ExTES-trained 7B	0.517	82.4	5.22	1.57	6.48	5.86

† scored without a reference need.

C. Memory (RQ5)

In dialogue. Table X compares three memory designs using the untuned 7B with four agents, no gate, and the corrective user whose situation changes between sessions. The runs use the same model and pipeline settings, with different memory designs.

Need-state memory has the highest Success estimate among the three displayed designs: 0.371 overall and 0.374 in sessions 2–4. The overall estimates are close, ranging from 0.361 to 0.371. Need-state and word-match memory both have IP 0.116, compared with 0.103 for summary memory. These are descriptive comparisons. Blocking of denied guesses could not be tested, because the simulated users almost never gave a clear denial.

TABLE X
MEMORY COMPARISON (UNTUNED 7B, FOUR AGENTS, 310 SESSIONS EACH)

Memory	Success (all)	Success (sess. 2–4)	IP
Summary	0.369	0.365	0.103
Word-match	0.361	0.361	0.116
Need-state	0.371	0.374	0.116

Are the stored beliefs right? Of the 785 stored needs, 90% matched one of the person's true needs, and confirmed needs were right 91% of the time. However, the memory's confidence numbers separate right from wrong beliefs only weakly. Re-fitting them from evidence the memory already stores (number of quotes, status, sessions seen) nearly halved the calibration error, so the structure holds useful signal that its hand-set rules do not yet use.

ES-MemEval. This benchmark uses real multi-session support histories: 18 users and 1,427 questions per memory type (Table XI). Each question was answered from the memory summary alone, with the same budget for every memory.

- The need-state memory tied with word-match retrieval for the best overall score, well above no memory and an event-based memory.

- It was best at modelling the user and reasoning about time.
- It kept a near-perfect score for not answering when it should not.
- It was weak at detecting conflicts, because it stores beliefs about needs, not the factual statements those questions test.

TABLE XI
ES-MEMEVAL: SHARE OF QUESTIONS ANSWERED CORRECTLY

Memory	All	Extract	User	Time	Conflict	Abstain
None	0.522	0.586	0.271	0.592	0.206	**0.989**
Summary	0.588	0.524	0.503	0.542	0.446	0.958
Word-match	**0.619**	**0.631**	0.536	0.549	**0.532**	0.866
Event	0.526	0.524	0.379	0.451	0.345	0.966
Need-state	**0.619**	0.586	**0.588**	**0.655**	0.292	**0.989**

D. The Safety Gate (RQ3)

The gate checks a draft before it reaches the user. A draft that fails the check is sent for revision; if the revised replies still fail, the system uses a neutral reflective fallback. This gives the system a way to act on the Critic's assessment before sending a reply.

Drafts stopped before release. At the selected thresholds, the saved calibration results contain 300 drafts for each Generator:

- **Untuned Generator:** the gate stopped 27.3% of all drafts, including 37.5% of the drafts judged intrusive.
- **Fine-tuned Generator:** the gate stopped 53.0% of all drafts, including 56.8% of the drafts judged intrusive.

The first percentage in each row uses all drafts as its denominator; the second uses only intrusive drafts. These are calibration-draft results, separate from the final reply-release shares reported in Section VII.

How this helps. Stopping an intrusive draft creates an opportunity to rewrite it before the user sees it. The fallback also lets the conversation continue when no candidate passes the check. In the untuned four-agent dialogue test, adding the gate reduced mean IP from 0.087 to 0.072, about a 17% reduction (Table XV). This is the measured benefit of adding a check between drafting and release.

Behaviour on the test profiles. With our profiles, the share of scored turns that were both released and intrusive was 0.046, with its full confidence interval below the 0.10 budget. With ExTES profiles, this share was 0.022 and the system used the reflective fallback on 65% of scored turns. In that setting, the fallback provided a response when the candidate did not pass the release checks.

E. Turn-Level Metrics (RQ4)

Plain PRI mixes the supporter's effect with the user's mood and style. For example, the corrective user pushes back more by design. Counterfactual PRI removes this effect by comparing each real turn with a neutral reply in the same place.

The systems fall into two groups:

- **No measurable caused resistance:** the one-call systems and the four-agent system with the gate.
- **Measurable caused resistance:** the four agents without the gate (+0.010), the fine-tuned models (+0.011 to +0.018), and the full system (+0.014).

So the methods that lower IP, namely the gate and DPO, also remove measurable resistance.

The turns that caused the most resistance are the kinds the IP items describe:

- probing at a sensitive moment ("Can you tell me more about what you were thinking right before the test started?");
- piling on validation;
- jumping to problem-solving ("Let's explore some new ideas together…").

These turn-level scores separated the agents from the gate when Success could not.

F. Model Steering and Preference Alignment (RQ6)

These experiments go beyond our proposal. Each method was compared with its own control on exactly the same sessions (Table XII).

DPO lowered the IP estimate by 0.027, with changes of +0.009 in Success and −0.001 in PRI. It also removed the measurable caused resistance and gave shorter replies, with no extra model calls. This is the largest IP drop against a matched control in our study. **Steering** showed an IP difference of −0.008. Table XII gives the differences and their IP confidence intervals.

TABLE XII
STEERING AND DPO AGAINST THEIR OWN CONTROLS (PAIRED, 310 SESSIONS)

Change	ΔIP	ΔPRI	ΔSuccess
Steering vs. no steering	−0.008 [−.013,−.003]	+0.011	−0.001
DPO vs. fine-tuned	**−0.027** [−.033,−.021]	−0.001	+0.009

G. Cost per Turn

We counted model calls per supporter turn from each pipeline's structure:

- one call: 1.00;
- one call with the gate: 3.33;
- four agents: 4.00;
- four agents with the gate: 5.36;
- full system: 4.32;
- steering and DPO: 1.00 each.

The gate costs 2–4 extra calls per turn. Steering and DPO lower IP with no extra calls.

H. Side Effects (RQ6)

We checked whether making the supporter gentler causes other problems.

Agreeing with harmful beliefs. We wrote 48 user turns showing distorted thinking, including risky plans such as

stopping medicine. No system became generally agreeable, and none was harsh. The exception was risky plans: the fine-tuned and DPO models went along with them about twice as often as the base model, while the gated pipelines stayed at the base level. For example, when a user said they would stop their antidepressants, the base model asked them to get all the information first. The fine-tuned model said "it's completely yours to make."

Emotional understanding. On the EmoBench test, fine-tuning may cost a little accuracy, and steering and DPO change nothing further; the intervals overlap.

Dependence. Reliance on the supporter was similar for all systems and did not grow across sessions. However, the four-agent and memory systems pointed the person to other people and outside help less often than the one-call systems, and respected the person's own decisions less.

I. How Reliable Is the Evaluation?

Second judge. A second open judge model rescored nine key systems. Every intrusiveness conclusion kept its direction under the second judge, except the small IP rise of the need-state memory.

Uncertainty. The tables retain the measured differences and their confidence intervals. Intrusiveness varies across configurations, while Success differences are generally small relative to their uncertainty. The supplementary result files retain the full comparison records.

VI. Ablation Study

A. Training With and Without Thoughts

Validation loss goes down as the model gets bigger (Table XIII). The third epoch overfits in every run, so we kept epoch 2. The losses of the two versions cannot be compared directly: one is averaged over thoughts plus reply, the other over the reply only.

TABLE XIII
Best Validation Loss

Version	0.5B	3B	7B
With thoughts	0.842	0.687	0.612
Without thoughts	0.876	0.696	0.489

How much do the thoughts tell the model about the reply? To compare the two versions fairly on the *same* reply words, we measured pointwise V-usable information (PVI) on the 2,608 validation turns:

$$\mathrm{PVI} = \log_2 p_{\text{with}}(y \mid x, t) - \log_2 p_{\text{without}}(y \mid x),$$

where y is the reply, x the conversation and t the thoughts. The thoughts carry a lot of useful information at every size, and less as the model grows (Table XIV, Fig. 6). The information is larger for deeper moves. A Qwen3-4B model from a different family gives similar values, so the effect is not just because Qwen2.5 wrote the corpus.

How the adapters use their capacity. We shrank each adapter to its best low-rank version. Bigger models need fewer directions to keep 95% of the gain: rank 16 for 0.5B, 4–8 for 3B and 2–4 for 7B. The main directions of the two versions overlap only a little, so training with thoughts changes *which* directions the adapter uses.

TABLE XIV
Useful Information in the Thoughts (Bits per Reply)

Model	Bits [95% CI]	PVI < 0	Loss cut
Qwen2.5-0.5B	8.91 [8.49, 9.34]	17.9%	18.5%
Qwen2.5-3B	7.36 [7.02, 7.72]	17.3%	19.2%
Qwen2.5-7B	3.31 [3.01, 3.62]	32.9%	12.4%
Qwen3-4B (control)	7.72 [7.41, 8.05]	15.5%	20.2%

In dialogue (Tables VI and VII, Fig. 5), the thoughts helped the 7B find needs (Success +0.023). This is the same direction as COCOON, which used a different judge and language. At 0.5B the thoughts did not help Success but made the model more intrusive (IP +0.021). A small model trained on the analysis seems to act on its guesses too early.

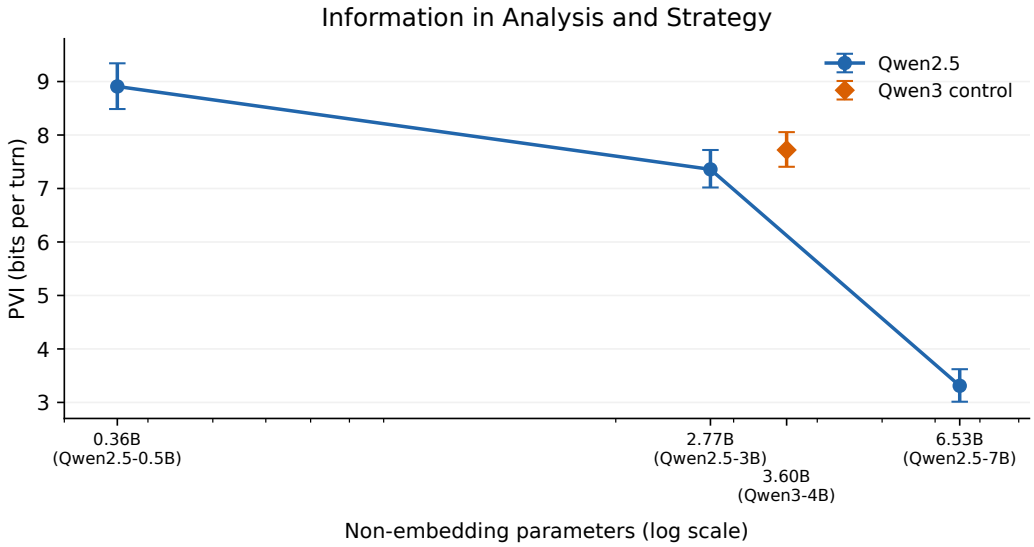


Fig. 6. PVI in bits per supporter turn on 2,608 validation turns. Error bars show the saved 95% bootstrap confidence intervals. Qwen3-4B is a separate-family control.

B. Agents and Gate: the 2×2

This is the central test from our proposal. It crosses one call against four agents, and gate off against gate on, using the untuned 7B so that only the design changes (Table XV).

1) **The gate lowers intrusiveness where there is some to remove.** With four agents it cuts IP by about a sixth and removes the measurable resistance the agents cause.
2) **Splitting into agents raises intrusiveness**, both without and with the gate. With an explicit Analyzer and Strategist, the untuned model acts on guesses it would otherwise keep to itself.
3) **No factor changes Success.**

Our proposal said: "If the gate carries the effect while decomposition alone contributes nothing, that is what we would report." The result is a little stronger: the gate carries the safety effect, and decomposition on its own makes things worse. The least intrusive cell is one call with the gate.

The gate also changes how the supporter talks. Replies get shorter and the listening score drops slightly. The gate makes replies safer, but also more cautious.

C. Memory On and Off for the Fine-Tuned Model

We ran the fine-tuned 7B over 2–4 sessions with and without the need-state summary, using the corrective user (Table XVI). Figure 7 shows these runs alongside the single-session references. The base model's Analyzer writes the memory, and the fine-tuned model only reads the summary, which it never saw in training.

Matching sessions by person and session number, the gain in sessions 2–4 is +0.028 [0.011, 0.045]. Over all sessions it is +0.013, with an interval that touches zero. The gain appears exactly where memory has something to carry: in session 1 the two are equal, and from session 2 on the memory version is ahead for every gap length and every kind of change. Intrusiveness is unchanged. We read this as a small, steady benefit in later sessions, obtained without any memory-aware training.

D. Steering Layer and Strength

Before the test, we fixed a rule for choosing the steering setting: among settings that keep Success close to the control, pick the one with the lowest intrusiveness. We tried layers 12 and 16 at three strengths on 20 calibration people. Layer 16 cut intrusiveness the most but lost too much Success, so the rule picked layer 12 at strength 0.2.

TABLE XV
THE 2 × 2: ONE CALL VS. FOUR AGENTS, GATE OFF VS. ON (UNTUNED 7B, 310 SESSIONS PER CELL; 95% CI)

Cell	Design	Success	AELS	IP	PRI	cf-PRI	Words	Calls/turn
A	one call, no gate	0.382 [.373,.392]	0.859	0.068 [.063,.072]	0.184	−0.003 [−.007,.002]	30.2	1.00
B	one call + gate	0.375 [.365,.386]	0.833	**0.061** [.057,.064]	0.187	−0.002 [−.007,.002]	25.9	3.33
C	four agents, no gate	0.379 [.368,.392]	0.849	0.087 [.081,.093]	0.203	**+0.010** [.005,.015]	23.2	4.00
D	four agents + gate	0.369 [.359,.380]	0.833	0.072 [.067,.077]	0.193	−0.004 [−.008,.001]	21.7	5.36

Differences: gate with four agents (D−C) IP −0.015 [−0.023, −0.007]; gate with one call (B−A) IP −0.007 [−0.013, −0.001]; agents without gate (C−A) IP +0.020 [0.012, 0.028]; agents with gate (D−B) IP +0.012 [0.006, 0.018]. The confidence intervals for the Success differences include zero.

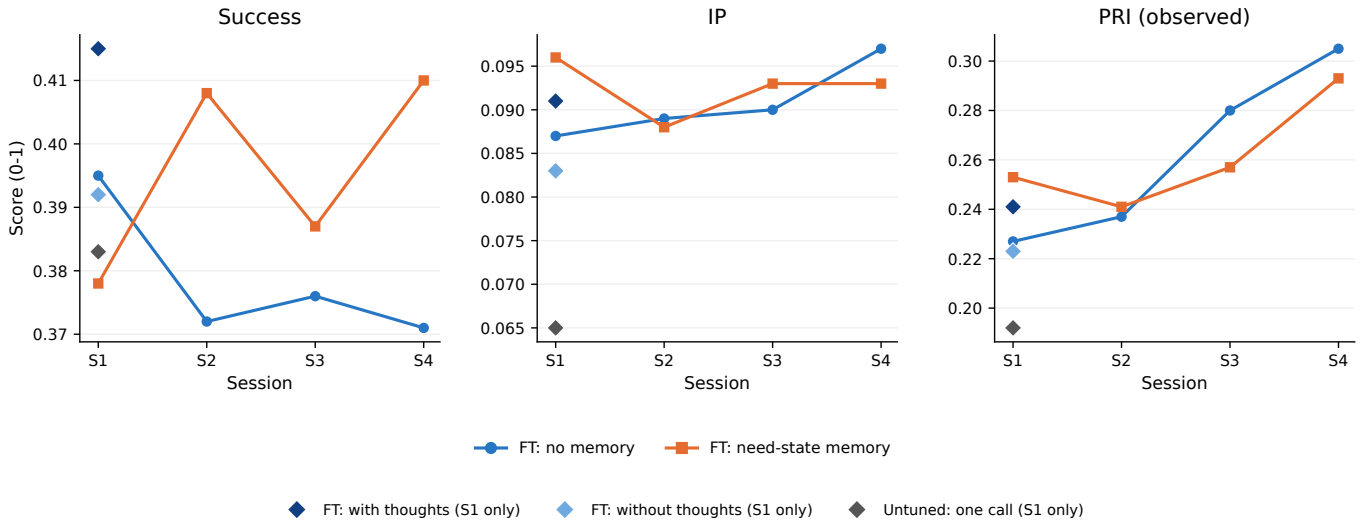


Fig. 7. Fine-tuned 7B with and without need-state memory across sessions S1–S4: Success, IP and observed PRI. Diamonds show the three single-session references. Multi-session runs use changing situations and a corrective user; the single-session references use a proactive user. Values come from the saved session summary, with 100, 100, 75 and 35 sessions respectively.

TABLE XVI
FINE-TUNED 7B WITH AND WITHOUT MEMORY (310 SESSIONS EACH)

	No memory	With memory
Success, all sessions	0.380 [.369,.391]	**0.394** [.383,.405]
Session 1	0.395	0.378
Session 2	0.372	0.408
Session 3	0.376	0.387
Session 4	0.371	0.410
IP	0.090	0.092

VII. FINAL INTEGRATED-SYSTEM RESULTS

The full system is the four-agent gated pipeline with the fine-tuned 7B as the Generator, its own calibrated gate and the need-state memory (Table XVIII). Against the same pipeline with the untuned Generator (cell D), it is more intrusive (IP +0.024) and has a larger reactance estimate (PRI +0.051), with similar Success.

Part of this gap comes from the software backend. Running the same untuned one-call supporter on both backends gives an IP difference of +0.017 for Transformers. On the same backend, the full system is about as intrusive as the fine-tuned one-call model with memory, and its gate falls back on only 1.6% of turns.

The combined run brings fine-tuning, all four agent roles, need-state memory and the calibrated gate into one evaluated system. The gate provides a checkpoint between drafting and release, allowing a flagged reply to be revised or replaced with a reflective fallback.

Gate output. Table XVII reports the share of scored turns that retained a generated reply instead of using the fallback. The untuned pipeline uses a threshold of 0.20; the full system uses its own calibrated threshold of 0.425. The corresponding shares are 84.0% and 98.4%. These are reply-release shares, not Success scores.

The untuned pipeline runs on Ollama with Q4 GGUF; the full system runs on Transformers with NF4. Their differences therefore reflect the combined configurations. In the full system, the saved share of turns both released and intrusive is 0.091 [0.074, 0.112]; its interval crosses the 0.10 budget.

TABLE XVII
GENERATED REPLIES RETAINED BY THE GATE ON SCORED TURNS

System (people)	Turns	Not fallback
Four agents + gate (ours)	1,240	84.0%
Full system (ours)	1,240	98.4%
Four agents + gate (ExTES)	400	35.0%

TABLE XVIII
THE FULL SYSTEM AND RELATED SYSTEMS (310 SESSIONS EACH)

System	Success	IP	PRI	cf-PRI
Four agents + gate, untuned	0.369	0.072	0.193	−0.004
Four agents, untuned	0.379	0.087	0.203	+0.010
Fine-tuned 7B + memory	0.394	0.092	0.254	+0.012
Full system	0.380	0.096	0.244	+0.014

cf-PRI = counterfactual PRI.

VIII. DISCUSSION

What the gate contributes. The gate turns the Critic's assessment into an action: release, revise or use a reflective fallback. In the untuned four-agent test, it reduced IP from 0.087 to 0.072. The calibration results also show that it intercepted 37.5% of intrusive untuned drafts and 56.8% of intrusive fine-tuned drafts. This makes the gate a useful check before a candidate reply reaches the user.

Calibration and use. The threshold sets how many drafts pass the check. Calibration and held-out testing make this choice measurable, while the fallback handles candidates that still fail after revision. The untuned four-agent test stayed within the stated risk budget. The full system's point estimate was also below 0.10, but its confidence interval crossed that budget, so the results do not establish the same bound for every configuration.

What training can do. The annotations carry real information, and they helped the 7B find needs, in line with COCOON; they made the small model more intrusive. DPO, trained on the Critic's own intrusiveness ratings, cut intrusiveness at no extra cost per turn. Like plain fine-tuning, though, it made the model more willing to go along with risky plans. Training changes behaviour cheaply, but it needs its own safety checks.

What memory adds. As a memory, the need-state design is competitive: it tied for the best ES-MemEval score and led on user modelling and reasoning about time. Its confirmed beliefs are usually right. In the untuned pipeline, its Success estimate was close to those of the other memory designs. With the fine-tuned model, it gave a small gain in later sessions.

Why turn-level metrics matter. Success barely separated the systems. Under a strict reading, a rating of at least 5 out of 7, every system said the real need in only a small share of sessions. Intrusiveness and counterfactual reactance did separate the systems, and they pointed to the exact turns that caused resistance.

IX. LIMITATIONS

- **Simulated users.** Every user is played by Qwen2.5-7B, the same family that wrote the corpus and plays the supporter. PRI therefore measures resistance shown by a simulated user, and we do not claim that it carries over to real people.

X. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

We rebuilt COCOON's approach to proactive emotional support in English with open models, and added four parts: a multi-session corpus, a four-agent supporter with a calibrated safety gate, turn-level intrusiveness and reactance metrics, and a need-state memory. Beyond our proposal, we also tested activation steering and preference alignment. The main findings are:

- the gate, not the agent split, controls intrusiveness;
- the annotations help larger models;
- preference alignment is a cheap and strong way to reduce intrusiveness;
- the need-state memory is competitive as a memory;
- turn-level metrics reveal differences that the overall success score misses.

Future work:

1) **More extensive dataset generation:** more people, more sessions per person, and more problem types, so that rarer situations are well covered.
2) **Combine DPO with the gate, and re-fit the memory's confidences** from the evidence the memory already stores.
3) **Collect real-world data from psychologists,** to ground the simulated users and to check our metrics against expert judgement.

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APPENDIX A
TEAM COMPOSITION AND CONTRIBUTIONS

The corpus pipeline, fine-tuning of the open model and turn-level metrics were shared work, as set in our project proposal. Individual responsibilities, including the later steering and DPO experiments, were:

- **Arpit Bhomia** (12340340, arpitba@iitbhilai.ac.in): time dynamics across sessions, the need-state memory and activation steering.
- **Ashish Ranjan** (12340370, ashishr@iitbhilai.ac.in): the inference architecture, including the multi-agent pipeline and the safety gate, and Direct Preference Optimization (DPO).

APPENDIX B
PROMPTS USED BY THE LLMS

These prompts were used by the LLMs to carry out two main tasks in our system: finding needs from the conversation and checking a draft reply before release. The excerpts below come from the project's actual Markdown prompt files. The full files also contain the input placeholders and required JSON output format.

A. Analyzer: Finding Needs from Evidence

Source: `prompts/agent_analyzer.md`. The pipeline fills this prompt with the conversation and memory summary. The LLM returns the emotional state, likely needs, evidence quotes and confidence values.

> You are the Analyzer in an emotional-support pipeline. You do not speak to the seeker. You read the conversation and report a psychological state in which EVERY claim is backed by a verbatim quote from a seeker turn.
> Rules: cite only lines labelled "seeker" - never the supporter's. Quotes must be copied character-for-character from the seeker turn you cite - do not paraphrase, do not fix typos. A claim you cannot quote for must be dropped, not softened. Confidence is your own calibrated belief in [0,1]: use low values when you are guessing. List at most 3 implicit needs.
> status_hint: "confirmed" only when the seeker agrees with or affirms a need that was already raised; "disconfirmed" when the seeker denies, rejects or pushes back on a need ("no, that's not it", "I don't need that"); "resolved" when the seeker says it is handled or no longer an issue; otherwise "hypothesis".

B. Critic: Checking a Reply Before Release

Source: `prompts/agent_critic.md`. The pipeline supplies the conversation, Analyzer output, plan, permitted depth, denied needs and draft reply. The LLM returns item scores, violations and rewrite feedback for the safety checks and gate.

> You are the Critic. Score the draft supporter turn for intrusiveness before it is released, using the Intrusiveness Penalty rubric, then say what to do with it.
> Score each item 1 (not at all) to 7 (very much):
> 1) Gave advice before the seeker had finished explaining their situation.
> 2) Asserted a feeling or motive the seeker had not expressed.
> 3) Named a need or cause the seeker had not acknowledged.
> 4) Pressed for information the seeker had signalled reluctance to give.
> 5) Interpreted the situation more deeply than the seeker had invited.
> 6) Disregarded a boundary the seeker had set.
> 7) Likely to feel exposing rather than supportive.
>
> Every item score is an integer from 1 to 7; score each item on its own evidence.